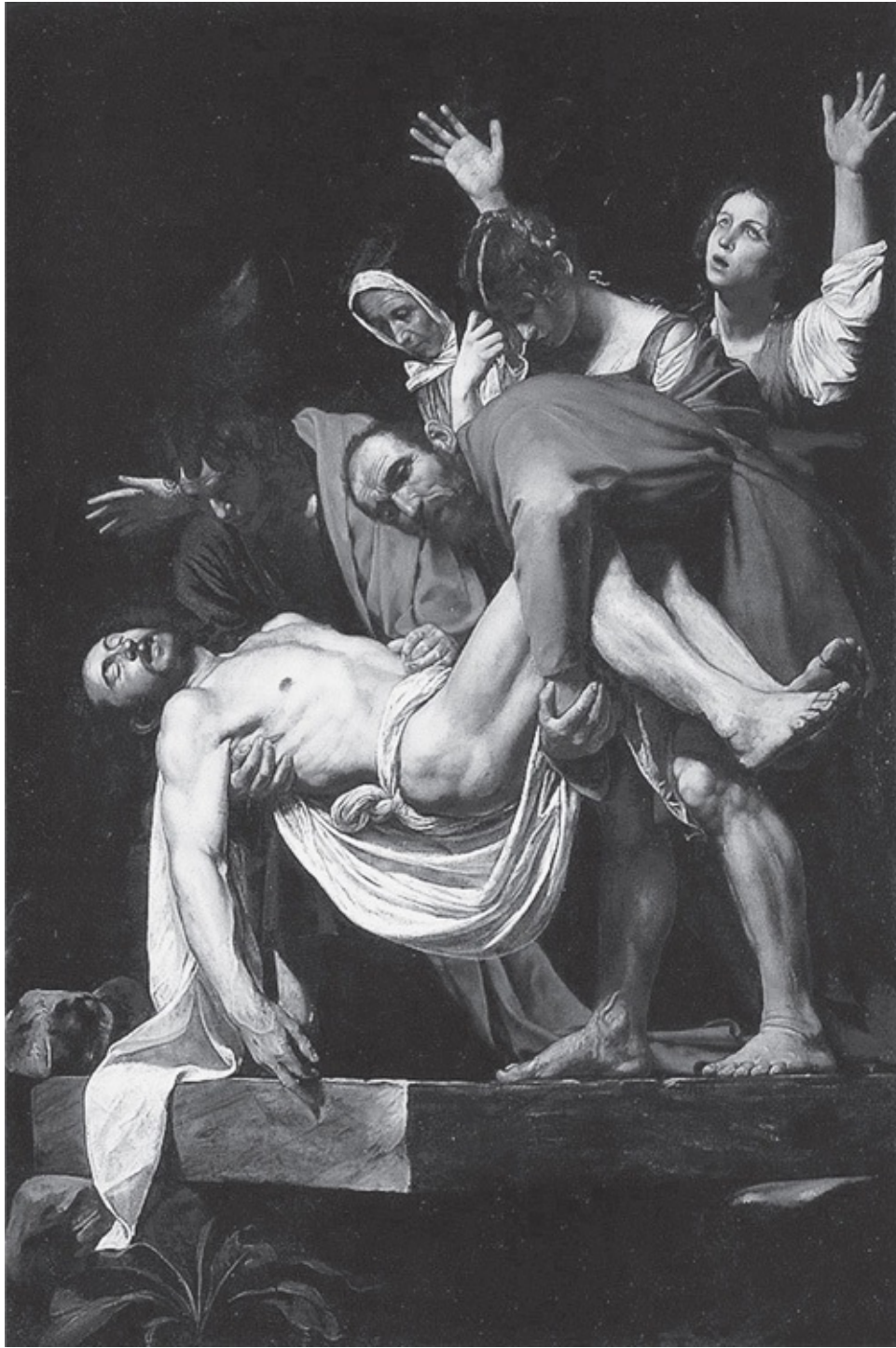


Light

From Caravaggio's tenebrism to Claude's golden glow, and from Friedrich's soft diffusions to Monet's vibrant colours, painters have always depicted light to enhance their effects. Depending on how it is used, light can create tonal contrasts, mood, atmosphere or something more tangible. Caravaggio, Wright of Derby, Gentileschi and de la Tour often used a single light source to focus viewers' attention on important elements in their paintings: strong light effects create drama and an impression of depth.

In a skilful artist's hands, light can be soft and gentle or sharp and bright, it can be uplifting or claustrophobic, mysterious or clear, warm or cool. Backlit landscapes draw viewers' eyes to the horizon, while light shining from the front casts a spotlight on the main action. Turner used bright colours and white, influencing the Impressionists who concentrated on capturing the optical impressions of light and its changing characteristics and moods in small, vibrantly coloured paint marks, often painting *alla prima* – or in one go – to capture shifting light effects.



Caravaggio, *The Entombment of Christ*, c.1602–3